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The Dark Side of Fandom: Exploring the Association between Parasocial Relationships with Celebrities and Aggression

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ABSTRACT

With the rapid proliferation of social media, individuals who admire certain celebrities—i.e. *fans*—now have access to extensive and increasingly interactive means to follow their idols and engage with fellow fans. While this has been linked to stronger parasocial relationships between fans and celebrities, as well as several psychological benefits such as a stronger sense of belonging, digital fan engagement might also reinforce conflicts between different fandoms. Referring to social identity theory, this pre-registered study explores the potential dark side of the contemporary fan experience. Allowing for cross-cultural comparisons, data were collected from 265 Chinese and German pop culture fans. The findings suggest that the strength of fans' parasocial relationships with their idols is positively related to in-group identification, out-group hostility, and behavioral aggression toward other fandoms. Intriguingly, cross-cultural differences emerged, as Chinese fans displayed higher levels of in-group identification, out-group hostility, and behavioral aggression toward other fandoms than German fans. Likewise, only the data from our Chinese participants revealed a moderating effect of social media use on the connection between parasocial relationships and out-group hostility.

Being a fan is a multi-faceted experience, typically characterized by both emotional and social investments. At its core lies a deep adoration (e.g., for a sports team, an actress, a music group), which is often shared by other like-minded individuals and may further translate into various positive thoughts, emotions, and behaviors, such as the inspiration felt during a live concert or the affectionate letter sent to a beloved idol. While many forms of fan engagement are associated with beneficial and adaptive outcomes, such as community bonding or the formation of a clear social identity, there are also more extreme instances in which fan behavior can take a darker turn. For example, within the realm of

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team sports, certain fringe groups—so-called hooligans—have drawn attention for their verbal or even physical aggression toward rival supporters (e.g., Toder-Alon et al., 2019; Wann & James, 2018). These instances, while unrepresentative of sports fans in general, highlight the potential of intense group affiliation to result in hostile out-group behavior under specific circumstances. Along similar lines, a number of much-publicized controversies have revealed inclinations for toxicity in modern pop culture; for example, the *GamerGate* controversy of the previous decade saw numerous female video game developers and journalists becoming the target of large-scale online harassment by male gamers (Massanari, 2017). While such instances should not be misconstrued as reflective of broader fan communities, they certainly underscore the possibility for a fan's admiration and/or sense of community to shift toward more sinister outcomes.

Apart from well-documented instances of fan hostility with regards to sports or specific entertainment domains, the potential "dark side" of fanship as part of a fan group (or *fandom*) has received only little scientific attention. Although some scholars have discussed the notion of *anti-fans*—people who feel strongly invested in their dislike toward a specific person, media, or genre (e.g., Gray, 2005; Jane, 2019; McRae, 2017)—much less is known about potentially toxic downstream effects that may arise from admiring a pop-cultural icon (e.g., singer, band, actor, model, or influencer). Even more so, we note that the psychological processes that might underpin fans' malicious thoughts, feelings, and behaviors toward those outside of their fandom have not yet received sufficient attention from media scholars. To overcome the identified research gaps, we scrutinize the role of parasocial relationships (PSRs) between fans and celebrities as a predictor for in-group identification, out-group hostility, and aggressive behaviors.

Whereas prior work on PSRs has long focused on traditional media, the triumph of mobile technologies and digital platforms has clearly transformed the scholarly investigation of fandom. In light of the extremely high (near full) prevalence and daily intensity of social media use across most demographic groups (DataReportal, 2025), many individuals employ social media as part of their fan experience. This might be explained by the option to have (seemingly) direct access to favorite celebrities or to receive *behind-the-scenes* information of celebrities' personal lives though their social media posts (Marwick & Boyd, 2011). Furthermore, social media platforms empower individuals to publicly share personal opinions, including enthusiasm, expressions of disdain, and verbal attacks directed at celebrities or other fandoms. Therefore, the current study also set out to examine the intensity of social media use as a moderating influence. Lastly, following a more exploratory approach, we conducted a comparative analysis of two distinct cultures that are traditionally characterized by different social dynamics—namely, a culture

rooted in individualistic values (i.e., Germany) and one rooted in collectivist values (i.e., China).

Theoretical Background

The Fan Experience: Fanship and Fandom

Fan culture represents a multifaceted phenomenon that encompasses various forms of cognitive, emotional, and behavioral engagement. While often used interchangeably, the terms *fanship* and *fandom* denote conceptually distinct aspects of the fan experience.

First, *fanship* generally refers to an individual's mental investment in a particular fan object (e.g., "I love this show"; Booth, 2010; Jenkins, 2012), encompassing not only cognitive and emotional aspects, but also behavioral expressions such as following news or attending corresponding events (Hinck, 2019). In contrast, *fandom* is inherently social, describing the collective identity and community-based dynamics organized around shared fan interests (e.g., "We love this show"; Booth, 2010). While fanship is anchored in personal identity, fandom constitutes a collective identity rooted in group affiliation and shared social meaning (Reysen & Branscombe, 2010; Reysen & Lloyd, 2012). Showing some overlap with the concept of fanship, fandom is similarly considered a multifaceted phenomenon—encompassing, to varying degrees, cognitive, affective, and behavioral components (Duffett, 2013; Hills, 2003; Stever, 2011). However, while emotional investment may often accompany individual fan engagement, it is not a necessary condition for fandom to occur. As Hills (2003) noted, fandom is more likely to involve interpretative practices, knowledge accumulation, and identity work, that is, processes that are not always driven by deep emotional intensity. Similarly, Duffett (2013) emphasized that fandom exists along a spectrum of engagement, including individuals who may be more intellectually or socially oriented in their fan practices. Therefore, equating fandom solely with affective intensity (or individual levels of fanship) represents a narrow and reductive view.

In his pioneering work on the fan experience, Jenkins (2012, 2019) emphasized that fans actively construct not only communities but also meanings around specific fan objects, thereby fostering participatory cultures and collective identities. Building on Jenkins' conceptualization, research has further elaborated on the social dynamics of fandoms, revealing that both online and offline fan interactions serve to co-construct shared cultural experiences (Booth, 2015). Moreover, research by Hinck (2019) has updated these ideas by highlighting that both fanship and fandom are increasingly shaped by digital infrastructures, algorithmic curation, and sociopolitical discourses. Her work underscores the need to analyze how platform-specific affordances influence and shape fan engagement in current times.

It should be noted that although fanship generally revolves around positive perceptions of the chosen fan object, there is also a contrasting phenomenon: Anti-fans, as defined by Gray (2003), are individuals who vehemently dislike a particular media character, product, or genre, perceiving it as foolish, stupid, morally bankrupt, and/or aesthetically devoid. Similar to fans, anti-fans actively engage with their chosen object of disdain. In various aspects, anti-fans can share similarities with fans, including attributes, behaviors, and performance (Gray, 2005). Additionally, Click (2019) highlighted how anti-fandom can mirror fandom in intensity and community dynamics, often structured by moral or even political convictions. Although being an anti-fan is certainly not a new phenomenon, the rapid proliferation of the Internet and various social media platforms in recent years has contributed to an increasing impact of related practices, with common behaviors such as hate speech and cyberbullying gaining more prominence (Jane, 2019).

Parasocial Phenomena as Part of the Fan Experience

Strongly related to—but, again, not synonymous with—the introduced terms fanship and fandom is parasociality, an important concept in the field of media psychology. Reaching back to a foundational paper from the 1950s (Horton & Richard Wohl, 1956), the term *parasocial interaction* (PSI) was coined to describe a type of perceptual illusion that occurs during people's immediate engagement with mass media. In their contribution, Horton and Richard Wohl (1956) argued that certain media characteristics may prompt audiences to experience an ostensible connection to the depicted individuals (i.e., media personae), which is perceived as intimate and reciprocal—even though the encounter is obviously one-sided. Complementing the construct of PSIs, scholarly work further established the notion of parasocial relationships (PSRs), which extend beyond the immediate exposure situation, describing a more sustained connection or emotional tie to a media persona (Dibble et al., 2016). Influential work by Rubin et al. (1985) laid the empirical groundwork for understanding parasocial processes, particularly in the context of television news, by demonstrating the psychological mechanisms and emotional responses involved in one-sided media relationships. Furthermore, Perse and Rubin (1989) demonstrated that individuals cognitively process parasocial relationships with soap opera characters in a similar way to real-life social interactions. Viewers assign both internal (dispositional) and external (situational) causes to the actions of media figures, suggesting that parasocial bonds involve complex psychological mechanisms. From this and other work, it is known that PSRs can manifest in diverse forms, ranging from feelings of friendship, admiration, or even imagined romantic partnerships to negative associations or antipathy directed toward individuals depicted in the media

(Hartmann, 2016). Returning to the topic at hand, PSRs refer to the illusion of a reciprocal, interpersonal bond with a media figure, despite the lack of real interactions. In contrast, fanship captures an individual's general degree of interest, admiration, and engagement toward a media character. Importantly, on a conceptual level, identifying as a fan does not necessarily imply the existence of a strong parasocial relationship.

To a certain extent, the rise of social media has decreased the psychological distance between celebrities and their fan base (e.g., Baek et al., 2013). The feeling of closeness to celebrities on social media can be attributed to several factors that enhance the perception of intimacy and accessibility: By sharing stories from their daily lives, celebrities create a sense of authenticity and relatability, which fosters a personal connection with their followers. Additionally, interactive features such as comment sections below social media content allow fans to engage in seemingly direct exchanges with celebrities, further reinforcing the perception of a reciprocal relationship. When celebrities speak directly to the camera and make eye contact (as is often the case in social media stories), it simulates face-to-face interaction, making the communication feel more personal and engaging, thereby strengthening PSRs (Liebers & Schramm, 2019). Notably, users who exhibit a stronger inclination to utilize social media to cultivate relationships are also more prone to developing intense PSRs with celebrities (Chung & Cho, 2017). However, empirical evidence also indicates that, in most cases, a certain distance still persists, as celebrities tend to interact more frequently with each other on social media platforms than with their fans (Bond, 2016; Stever & Lawson, 2013). Thus, notwithstanding the evolving digital landscape, interpersonal dynamics between fans and celebrities largely retain their traditionally parasocial nature, given the inherent sparsity of their interactions.

Importantly, several studies have provided empirical evidence that fanship, fandom, and heightened PSRs can—both directly and indirectly—influence individuals' emotional intensity and behavioral intentions (e.g., Chung & Cho, 2017; Gleason et al., 2017; Kim et al., 2015), suggesting relevant interrelations between all three concepts. For instance, it has been found that PSRs can enhance feelings of connection and community, which arguably relates to the notion of fandom (Hoffner & Bond, 2022). In line with this finding, a study conducted by Kim et al. (2023) demonstrated that both online interactions and resulting PSRs with celebrities provide a sense of virtual community, playing a pivotal role in many people's social well-being. Moreover, Liu (2023) found that PSRs positively impact fan community participation (i.e., participating in discussions and creating fan-made media content). Similarly, individuals' team identity in the context of sports was found to be positively related to PSRs with the team players (Mikkilineni et al., 2023). In a systematic review, Sahharon et al. (2023) revealed that through fostering a shared identity, a sense of belonging, task commitment, and social trust, interactions within virtual

communities not only enable users to engage in networking practices but also augment the sense of social cohesion. However, it is important to reiterate that, on a conceptual level, identifying as a fan does not necessarily imply the existence of a strong parasocial relationship with the admired figure—especially if the social aspects of fandom are deemed much more important than the emotional aspects of the individual's fanship.

Fandom Through the Lens of Social Identity Theory

In today's scholarly understanding, the fan experience can be systematically categorized based on varying degrees of intensity, types of interest in celebrities, and motivations for engaging in the corresponding fandom (Stever, 2009). In the context of the present study, we define a fan as someone who demonstrates ongoing affective investment and behavioral engagement toward a fan object, which may or may not involve community membership or parasocial intimacy (e.g., Booth, 2010; Jenkins, 2012). Yet, we also note that the ongoing triumph of social media and mobile technologies has clearly accentuated interdependent aspects of being a fan, providing those interested in any given fan object with many opportunities to express and share their love for their favorite celebrity.

By these means, fandom also plays an increasingly vital role in constructing and maintaining many individuals' social identity in the sense of the well-renowned *social identity theory* (SIT; Tajfel & Turner, 1979). The theory posits that personal identity and social group memberships are intricately linked, mutually shaping an individual's self-concept, as well as their sense of belonging and social identity. SIT further suggests that intergroup behavior is influenced by the desire to achieve positive distinctiveness for one's in-group, often leading to in-group favoritism and out-group discrimination as mechanisms to enhance self-esteem. For example, it has been shown that being a sports team fan constitutes an integral part of many people's identity, bringing several meaningful advantages such as social support or greater life satisfaction—even if it may occur at the expense of other teams and their admirers (e.g., Wann, 2006). Proceeding to a different domain, similar dynamics have also been observed among both TV and music fans, whose social (fan) identity was found to significantly contribute to relational and physical well-being via in-group association (Vinney et al., 2019). Along the same lines, Courbet and Fourquet-Courbet (2014) reported evidence that the death of an admired celebrity may make it necessary for devoted fans to rearrange their personal identity and to engage in shared mourning processes.

Moreover, in recent years, the intricate connection between people's fanship and their social identity has increasingly been scrutinized among fans of South Korean pop music (so-called *K-pop stans*), as these fandoms often seem particularly invested in identity dynamics (Cho, 2022; Malik & Haidar,

2023). Indeed, related research has highlighted a certain competitive performativity among K-pop fans that may manifest through intra-fandom competition (concerning members of the same group) as well as fandom–fandom competition (involving battles between different groups). More specifically, it has been found that both of these dynamics are directly linked to perceptions of fan loyalty toward a favored celebrity or group—meaning that a strong identification with the own K-pop fandom seems to imply the need to compete with other fandoms for many fandom members (Tinaliga, 2018).

In addition, recent research drawing on SIT highlights how fans in the realm of entertainment media use communication strategies to assert dominance and achieve internal stratification as a crucial intra-fandom dynamic (Hubbard et al., 2024). According to this line of work, being part of the same fandom—and thus, sharing a social fan identity with others—does not necessarily result in perceptions of equal in-group membership. Instead, fans seem to engage in processes of ranking and comparison within their community, creating distinctions of "better" or "more authentic" fans (Hills, 2003). In turn, such hierarchical thinking can reinforce in-group competition and, in some cases, foster exclusionary or hostile behaviors toward others. Underscoring the potential power of fan hierarchies, recent work further emphasizes that these stratifications contribute to toxic fan interactions—legitimizing power imbalances within fan communities (Hubbard et al., 2024).

Looking at the Potential Dark Side of Fanship and Fandom

Although belonging to a fan group typically elicits many profoundly positive outcomes, there also seems to be a potential downside to the strong in-group bond that connects fan community members. As detailed above, this can concern both competitive behaviors between members of the same fandom, as well as inter-fandom toxicity—with negative consequences affecting both in- and out-group members. For instance, sports fans displaying high levels of in-group identification have reported heightened anxiety and physiological arousal before and during competitions involving their team (Branscombe & Wann, 1992). Additionally, research by Branscombe et al. (1993) demonstrated that highly identified individuals exhibit in-group extremism, manifesting in a tendency to judge in-group members more critically than out-group individuals. Relatedly, passionate football fans suffer from higher levels of somatization, interpersonal sensitivity, and psychoticism than non-fans (Leite et al., 2020). Additionally, profound group phenomena such as in-group protectionism and favoritism can increase the perception of conflict and antagonism toward out-groups (Lee, 2012; White et al., 2021). More concretely, the amplification of social identification in intergroup conflict correlates with heightened negativity toward out-groups, as well as belligerent

thoughts toward rival fandoms (Stephan & Stephan, 2017; Turner & Reynolds, 2011).

Researchers have characterized problematic behaviors in such competitive scenarios as *toxic fan practices* (Proctor & Kies, 2018). These behaviors are assumed to emerge due to disrupted and destabilized collective beliefs, where fans engage in fierce competition to uphold their dominance within a dynamic field (Hills, 2018). Consequently, conflict and combat must be considered as integral aspects of the fan experience for many individuals, shaped by a complex interplay of social identity, community belonging, and loyalty to the celebrity (Proctor, 2017). Arguably, the digital age has only amplified these dynamics, with social media platforms acting as catalysts that intensify fan aggression and facilitate the rapid spread of toxic behaviors across fandom communities. To address these developments, the current study aimed to examine the interplay of fandom identity, PSRs, hostile cognitions, and behavioral intentions in relation to the use of modern social media.

Based on the reviewed literature and arguments, we first assume that the intensity of a fan's emotional tie to an admired celebrity is related to a stronger sense of group identification. Moreover, referring to the well-established psychological principle (SIT; Tajfel & Turner, 1979) that group membership fosters positive *and* negative intergroup dynamics, we expect further associations between PSRs, hostile thoughts and behavior. Taken together, we hypothesize:

H1: The strength of the parasocial relationship between a fan and a celebrity is positively associated with (a) in-group identification, (b) out-group hostility, and (c) behavioral aggression against other fandoms.

The Moderating Role of Social Media Use Intensity

As outlined above, social media have facilitated the development of more intimate connections between fans and their beloved idols, as well as the bonds within fan communities (Tatem & Ingram, 2022). Accordingly, the actual time devoted to engaging with their own fandom on social media might exert a direct and favorable impact on the levels of trust and in-group identification individuals have with their respective fan communities. This, in turn, increases the overall loyalty among members within the fandom (Kim & Kim, 2017). Interactions on social media have the potential to foster a sense of intimacy, feelings of connectedness, and perceived friendship. In a similar vein, the engagement with social media content that is rich in personal details (and thus provides new information) can ultimately strengthen the development of PSRs with celebrities (Chung & Cho, 2017). Along these lines, social media clearly play a significant role in strengthening PSRs by fostering fans'

emotional connections, fulfilling their needs for entertainment, social interaction, and information (Zafina & Sinha, 2024). Beyond the positive impact of social media on PSRs, however, a recent study investigating fanaticism and cyberbullying among football fans also highlights the negative potential of social media as a fan outlet. Fans who use social media primarily for entertainment purposes are significantly more prone to engaging in cyberbullying compared to those who do not. These findings emphasize the influence of social dynamics and digital platforms in fostering behavioral aggression (Simsek & Ozturk, 2024). In summary, the second hypothesis was as follows:

H2: The relationship specified in H1a–c is moderated by the intensity of social media use.

Exploring Cultural Differences

In order to explore the discussed dynamics in a comprehensive manner, it also seems crucial to examine them through a cultural lens. After all, intergroup dynamics are also famously shaped by cultural norms, values, and orientations (Brown & Pehrson, 2019). In an important capacity, this involves the cultural dimension of interdependence, sometimes also referred to as a culture's level of *collectivism*: Whereas many Western societies emphasize an independent self-view, contrasting perspectives emerge in several cultures in the Global East and South, tying a person's self-definition to their interpersonal relationships and position in society (Hofstede, 2011). Connecting this perspective to the core assumptions of SIT, individuals' culturally influenced levels of collectivism may also impact their habitual in-group identification, as well as the expression of social behaviors in online contexts (Zhong, 2022). Moreover, the varying levels of digital connectivity found within different cultures may further affect how fans interact with celebrities and each other. For instance, users with collectivist values have repeatedly been found to focus on more intense social interactions via social media than those with individualistic values (Hsu et al., 2015; Sheldon et al., 2017).

Returning to the topic at hand, at least some aspects of the fan experience (e.g., the human desire for mutual social support, the tendency to form social identities) are inherently human and, therefore, somewhat universal. Even more so, the convergence of technology, globalization, and internet connectivity has increased the likelihood that individuals from diverse cultures express their admiration for the same celebrity, thereby fostering the development of cross-cultural fandom. In line with this argument, Chin and Morimoto (2013) found that cultural disparities or similarities do not determine an individual's propensity to become a fan. Nevertheless, the described cultural impact

on typical human intergroup dynamics could still pave the way for nuanced differences between fandom experiences in different societies. To engage this assumption in an exploratory manner, the current study further involves a cross-cultural comparison between fans from a more independent (Germany) and a more interdependent (China) society, according to current cultural scientific categorizations (The Culture Factor, 2025). Considering that there is yet little insight into different fan dynamics across the globe, we settled for an open-ended research question:

RQ1: Are there cross-cultural differences between Chinese and German fans regarding the effects specified in H1 and H2?

Exploring Situational Differences

Concluding our work, we decided to put additional focus on the behavioral level; ultimately, the question arises as to which circumstances feel particularly provoking for fans so that they feel the need to attack other fans. Referring to van Goozen et al. (1994), we focus on six situations that might be especially relevant to trigger intergroup conflicts: First, situations where false information about a fan's idol circulates. These might be, for instance, rumors that can harm the idol's reputation. Second, situations where someone else's opinion of the idol (and their qualities, achievements, and influence) is less favorable than the fan's own view. Third, situations where others make demeaning or mocking remarks about the idol. This direct belittling might be perceived as incredibly offensive as it disrespects the idol and their accomplishments. Fourth, fans may also feel offended when their idol is unfavorably compared to other celebrities, regardless of talent, personality, or popularity. Fifth, collaborations between a fan's idol and a public figure or celebrity whom the fan dislikes might also be perceived as challenging. Sixth, rivalries between different fan groups may trigger fans to defend their idol's honor and fandom's reputation against perceived rivals. To the best of our knowledge, no prior research compared fans' reactions to these different situations within the context of pop culture. Therefore, the following explorative research question was added to our research propositions:

RQ2: In which scenarios will fans' aggressive feelings and intentions to improve their idols' situation turn out to be particularly strong?

Method

Ethics Statement

Although institutional ethics approval is not mandatory for psychological research in Germany unless it involves legally regulated matters, the present study adhered fully to the Declaration of Helsinki and the ethical guidelines of the German Psychological Society (DGPs). This included obtaining informed consent from all respondents prior to their participation. Due to the nature of our investigation, no specific risks (e.g., physical or mental harm) were to be expected for our participants.

Procedure

A preregistered (see https://aspredicted.org/n55s-xzgt.pdf) online survey was conducted to collect data from popular culture fans who currently admire a celebrity. For the sake of our cross-cultural examination, the survey was translated into German and Chinese with the help of native speakers. After reading a short introduction about the topic of the study, participants provided their informed consent and were asked to indicate whether they currently considered themselves an active or avid fan of a pop-cultural idol (either a singer, a band, an actor, a model, or a social media influencer); those answering this question negatively were screened out. Next, participants self-reported their behavioral aggression, out-group hostility against other fandoms, in-group identification with the fandom, and trait anger as a dispositional control variable. The second part of the questionnaire contained brief descriptions of six specific scenarios (see above) in which fans may feel offended and angry. After each scenario, participants self-reported their aggressive feelings and intention to improve the situation. On the next pages, they provided information concerning the strength of their PSR with their favorite celebrity and the intensity of their social media use. At the end of the survey, participants answered several demographic questions and an attention check item (i.e., "How conscientiously did you fill out the questionnaire?"). All used materials, as well as the anonymized data of our participants, can be obtained from an Open Science Framework repository (https://osf.io/g6cuw/).

Participants

The sample size was determined before data collection using G*Power 3.1 (Faul et al., 2007). Considering a target effect size for our power calculations in this exploratory research effort, we opted to aim for medium effects of at least $f = .15$. The results showed that, for multiple regressions, 77 participants for each nationality (i.e., Chinese and German) would be required to achieve a statistical power of .80 (alpha level = .05). A total of 341 participants were

recruited using the Chinese social media platform Weibo, college student groups at both German and Chinese universities, and K-pop groups on Facebook. Those who did not identify themselves as fans of any celebrity in popular culture at the beginning of the survey ($n = 55$) were excluded from the data analysis. Furthermore, 15 participants were excluded due to implausibly short or long completion times, and six participants failed the attention check. Excluding these participants led to a final sample of $N = 265$. Among them, 50.6% ($n = 134$) were German and 49.4% ($n = 131$) Chinese. 89.4% ($n = 237$) identified as female, 10.2% ($n = 27$) as male, and one participant as third gender. Their age ranged from 16 to 55 ($M = 25.63$, $SD = 5.53$). 60.75% ($n = 161$) had a bachelor's degree or higher.

Measures

All measures described below focused on participants' general psychological connections to their chosen fan objects rather than on specific fan identities or subgroups. For reasons of standardization, we decided not to compare specific fan objects (e.g., music artists vs. social media influencers) but instead focused on broader mechanisms across all entertainment-related fan contexts. Along these lines, participants were not asked to specify their specific fandom, as our primary interest lay in dynamics that might apply to any fanship experience in the realm of popular culture. As a byproduct, this approach served to mitigate social desirability bias, as we did not want participants to answer less freely after explicitly identifying their favored fan object.

Strength of PSR

The *Multiple PSR Scale* (Tukachinsky, 2010) was used to measure the strength of participants' PSR to their admired idol. Its 24 items cover the dimensions of communication (e.g., "I think my idol could be a friend of mine," Cronbach's $\alpha = .86$), support and companionship (e.g., "I want to promote the well-being of my idol," $\alpha = .89$), physical attraction (e.g., "I find my idol very attractive physically," $\alpha = .92$), and emotional response to the respective celebrity (e.g., "I adore my idol," $\alpha = .84$). Participants responded to these items on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 *(totally disagree)* to 5 *(totally agree)*.

Fan Identification, Hostility, and Aggression

A 15-item scale was developed using selected items from the *Aggression Scale* (Buss & Perry, 1992), resulting in the following three dimensions: In-group identification (e.g., "The hatred of other fandoms proves that I belong to my own fandom," $\alpha = .62$), out-group hostility (e.g., "I am suspicious of what motivates the actions of other fandoms," $\alpha = .76$), and behavioral aggression against other fandoms (e.g., "I often argue with other fandoms," $\alpha = .64$).

Participants rated all items on a scale from 1 (*totally disagree*) to 5 (*totally agree*).

Trait Anger

Anger served as a dispositional control variable as it can motivate hostile spectator aggression and violent actions aimed at harming others (Wann et al., 1999). It was measured using three items (e.g., "I have trouble controlling my anger") that were selected from the *Aggression Scale* (Buss & Perry, 1992), with one additional item added by the study authors to yield higher face validity ("I do not usually feel angry easily"; recoded). The participants responded to these four items on a scale ranging from 1 (*totally disagree*) to 5 (*totally agree*). Internal consistency turned out high (Cronbach's $\alpha = .80$).

Intensity of Daily Social Media Use

A three-item scale ($\alpha = .71$) was created to assess participants' social media use intensity. The first item addressed the duration of general social media use. The second question referred to the time the participant searched for information about their idol on social media. The last item asked about the participants' fan engagement in terms of interacting and communicating with their favorite stars and other fandom members. For each of these items, five answering options were presented, ranging from "less than one hour" (option 1) to "more than four hours per day" (option 5). During our data analysis, a social media use index variable was averaged from all three items.

Aggressive Feelings and Behavioral Intentions in Different Situations

Inspired by scenarios described within the renowned *Anger Situation Questionnaire* (van Goozen et al., 1994), two items were developed to measure participants' emotional reactions and behavioral intentions in six different situational contexts. As introduced in the theoretical section, we introduced participants to the following aversive situations: (1) non-fans spreading rumors about the idol, (2) non-fans evaluating the idol's qualities and achievements negatively, (3) non-fans verbally belittling idol, (4) non-fans comparing the idol unfavorably to other celebrities, (5) the idol collaborating with another, disliked celebrity, and (6) direct verbal altercations with another fandom. After reading each scenario, the respondents indicated the intensity of their aggressive feelings (single item, i.e., "I would have very strong aggressive feelings in this situation") and whether they would attempt to improve their idols' situation by defending them (single item, i.e., "I would certainly take action to improve this situation"). These items were rated on a scale ranging from 1 (*does not match at all*) to 5 (*totally matches*).

Table 1. Zero-order correlations between study variables.

Variable	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
(1) Age	–						
(2) Gender	.16*	–					
(3) Behavioral Aggression	−.05	.08	–				
(4) Out-group Hostility	.01	.04	.51**	–			
(5) Ingroup Identification	.01	.07	.53**	.56**	–		
(6) Trait Anger	−.03	.05	.20**	.17**	.13*	–	
(7) PSR	−.13	−.03	.28**	.33**	.36**	.09	–

Note. *$p < .05$; **$p < .01$.

Results

Main Analysis

Data were analyzed using SPSS. Zero-order correlations between all variables are presented in Table 1. To answer hypotheses H1 and H2, hierarchical regression analyses were conducted, predicting each of our three outcome variables (i.e., in-group identification, out-group hostility, and behavioral aggression against other fandoms) by the strength of PSR, before adding the control variable (i.e., trait anger) and the interaction term between the intensity of social media use and the strength of PSR in a second step.

As predicted in H1a–c, the strength of PSR between fan and celebrity was significantly positively associated with participants' perceived (a) in-group identification, $\beta = .36$, $t(263) = 6.15$, $p < .001$, $R^2 = .12$, (b) out-group hostility, $\beta = .33$, $t(263) = 5.72$, $p < .001$, $R^2 = .11$, and (c) behavioral aggression against other fandoms, $\beta = .28$, $t(263) = 4.70$, $p < .001$, $R^2 = .07$. This pattern persisted even after adding trait anger (which, in itself, did not significantly predict any of the outcome variables). Yet, unlike our positive answer to H1, the intensity of social media use did not significantly interact with PSR strength when explaining variance in in-group identification ($p = .172$), out-group hostility ($p = .160$), and behavioral aggression against other fandoms ($p = .416$). Thus, H2a–c had to be rejected.

Cross-Cultural Comparison

Addressing RQ1, independent *t*-tests were conducted to explore potential differences between Chinese and German fans in their degree of in-group identification, out-group hostility, and behavioral aggression against other fandoms (see Figure 1), as well as the additional impact of social media use. First, we found significant cultural differences for all three outcomes. Chinese fans demonstrated significantly higher levels of in-group identification ($M = 2.61$, $SD = 0.93$) compared to German fans ($M = 1.94$, $SD = 0.85$), $t(263) = 6.16$, $p < .001$, $d = .72$. Furthermore, Chinese fans self-reported higher levels of out-group hostility ($M = 2.72$, $SD = 0.94$) than German fans ($M = 2.35$, $SD = 0.98$), $t(263) = 3.13$, $p = .002$, $d = .33$. Lastly, Chinese fans showed a higher level of

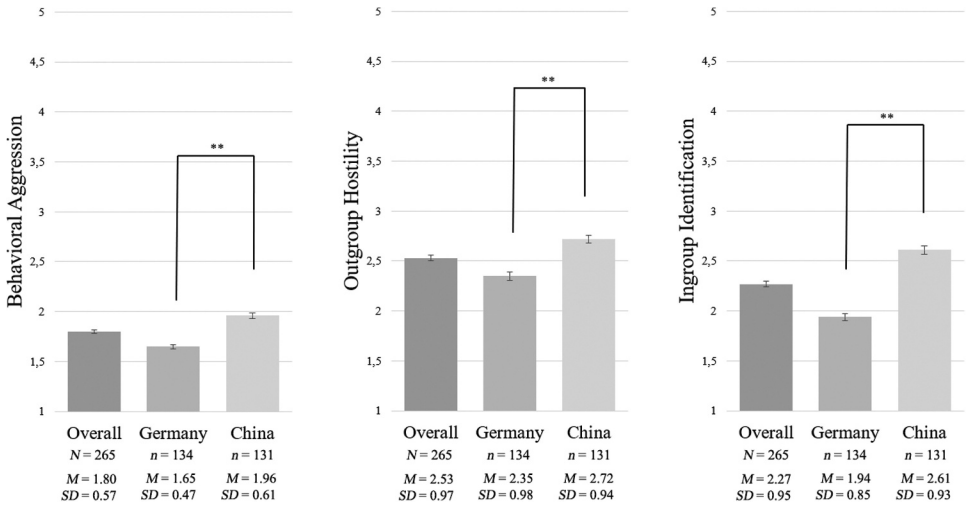

Figure 1. Cross-cultural group differences in the study variables. *Note*. *$p < .05$; **$p < .01$

behavioral aggression against other fandoms ($M = 1.96$, $SD = 0.61$) compared to German fans ($M = 1.65$, $SD = 0.47$), Welch's $t(243.119) = 4.59$, $p < .001$, $d = .49$.

Proceeding to our comparative investigation of social media use as a potential moderator, the data of our German sub-sample did not reveal significant moderation effects of daily social media use on the relationship between PSR and either in-group identification, $b = 0.07$, $t(129) = 0.48$, $p = .631$, out-group hostility, $b = 0.03$, $t(129) = 0.25$, $p = .804$, or behavioral aggression, $b = 0.12$, $t(129) = 1.91$, $p = .058$. For Chinese fans, on the other hand, daily social media use significantly moderated the relationship between the strength of PSRs and out-group hostility, $b = -0.38$, $t(126) = -2.41$, $p = .017$. Simple slope analyses revealed that the relationship between the strength of PSR and out-group hostility was only significant for individuals who scored low in social media use but not for those with medium or high levels. Conversely, the intensity of social media use did not moderate the relationship between PSRs and the other two outcome variables–i.e., in-group identification, $b = -0.30$, $t(126) = -1.44$, $p = .153$, and behavioral aggression, $b = -0.11$, $t(124) = -1.33$, $p = .211$.

Aggressive Feelings and Behavioral Intentions in Different Situations

RQ2 aimed to identify whether specific situations lead to different levels of aggressive feelings and the willingness to improve the situation with defensive fan behaviors. Repeated measures ANOVAs with Huynh-Feldt correction revealed that the type of situation had a significant effect on both aggressive feelings, $F(4.53, 1196.57) = 30.65$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.10$, and the willingness to improve the situation, $F(4.30, 1135.67) = 120.67$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.31$.

Table 2. Descriptive statistics for reported aggression and willingness to take defensive actions in different fan scenarios.

	Aggressive feelings		Willingness to take defensive action	
Fan scenario	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*
Non-fans spreading rumors about the idol	2.21	1.03	3.23	1.08
Non-fans negatively evaluating the idol's qualities/achievements	1.99	0.95	2.80	1.11
Non-fans belittling the idol	2.37	1.09	3.08	1.08
Non-fans unfavorably comparing the idol to other celebrities	2.31	1.18	2.81	1.19
Idol working together with a disliked celebrity	1.70	0.89	1.68	0.99
Altercation with members of another fandom	2.16	1.16	2.36	1.16

Situation-specific statistics (i.e., *M* and *SD*) are summarized in Table 2. For details on our post hoc analyses, please consult the Supplementary Analyses file provided in the project's OSF. Participants' aggressive feelings increased across the scenarios as follows (from lowest to highest): Idol works with a disliked celebrity, negative evaluation of the idol's qualities and achievements, conflict with another fandom, spreading rumors about the idol, unfavorable comparison of the idol with other celebrities, and verbally belittling the idol. Whereas the lowest and highest values significantly differed from each other, this was not the case for all scenarios between these rankings. Concerning participants' willingness to improve the situation, the scenarios' ranking turned out slightly different, again from lowest to highest: Idol works with a disliked celebrity, conflict with another fandom, negative evaluation of the idol's qualities and achievements, unfavorable comparison of the idol with other celebrities, verbally belittling the idol, and spreading rumors about the idol. With only two exceptions (i.e., between the two lowest and highest values, respectively), all of these ranking differences were significant.

Discussion

The primary aim of the present study was to investigate whether and to what extent PSRs between media users and celebrities can lead to negative emotions and behavioral aggression toward other fandoms. As hypothesized, we found that the strength of PSRs was related to in-group identification, out-group hostility, and aggressive behaviors (H1a–c). This not only underscores the central role of parasociality in media users' thoughts, feelings, and behaviors—but also aligns well with Brewer's (1999) social psychological interpretation that individuals' sense of belonging to a social group fosters both a strong protective stance toward one's own group and the concomitant hostility toward others.

By specifically exploring these dynamics among fans of pop-cultural idols, the present study advances the scholarly understanding of fan identity and behavior—extending the focus of previous studies (which mostly investigated the sports domain) to the popular entertainment fandoms of our time.

Consequently, we believe that our findings contribute to a more comprehensive view of how social identification and intergroup conflict manifest within contemporary fan communities surrounding singers, actors, bands, and influencers. As demonstrated, individuals who experience strong PSRs with media figures may invoke hostile cognitions, negative feelings, and even related behavioral intentions to protect the celebrities toward whom they feel strong emotional connections. Given that parasocial bonds can evoke feelings akin to close friendships or imagined romantic connections (Hartmann, 2016), aggressive reactions toward those who criticize or reject the admired persona—such as out-group members—may be perceived as justified or protective responses.

Contrary to our expectations, however, social media use intensity did not moderate the relationship between the strength of PSR and either in-group identification, out-group hostility, or behavioral aggression directed at other fandoms (see H2a–c)—at least for our full sample. Several theoretical considerations might explain these non-significant findings. First, the role of PSRs for the observed outcomes may be driven more by the quality or nature of the accompanying parasocial interactions than by the sheer frequency of social media use. According to SIT (Tajfel & Turner, 1979), the strength of identification with a group is influenced by meaningful interactions and salient group-related content rather than the volume of exposure alone. Thus, if social media use does not consistently involve content that strengthens the media users' PSR, or reinforces their group identity or rivalry, sheer usage duration might turn out less relevant. Second, the non-significant moderation effect might suggest that PSRs are sufficiently robust in shaping attitudes and behaviors without needing reinforcement through frequent social media usage. For example, once a strong PSR is established, the psychological investment in the relationship might be maintained with minimal social media engagement. This aligns with research indicating that strong PSRs can endure over time, even with sporadic interaction (Giles, 2002). Third, contextual factors could also explain the lack of a moderation effect; one example might be if individuals use social media in ways that do not align with competitive or aggressive fandom behaviors (e.g., for passive consumption rather than active participation).

Additionally, this study aimed to explore potential differences in aggressive behaviors among fans from China and Germany (see RQ1). The findings revealed that—in direct comparison—Chinese fans exhibited higher levels of in-group identification, out-group hostility, and behavioral aggression toward other fandoms. Thus, despite the fact that idol culture in some aspects is nowadays considered a global phenomenon, there seems to be additional value in observing culture-specific differences, potentially in connection to dimensions such as individualism–collectivism (Hofstede, 2011; Triandis, 1996, 2001). Several mechanisms may underlie these culture-specific patterns:

First, stronger in-group identification in collectivist contexts may amplify the salience of perceived out-group threats, increasing the likelihood of hostile reactions. Accordingly, collectivism-oriented fans may experience a heightened sense of responsibility to uphold group norms and defend the social image of their fandom, which can manifest in behaviors perceived as aggressive toward other groups. In contrast, fans in more individualistic contexts, such as Germany, may focus more on personal enjoyment and autonomy rather than inter-fandom rivalry, reducing the intensity of out-group hostility. Second, social comparison processes may operate differently across cultures (Baldwin & Mussweiler, 2018). In China, where interdependence is traditionally emphasized, individuals may more readily compare their fandom's status to others, heightening sensitivity to perceived slights or competition. In Germany, on the other hand, social comparisons may be more self-referential, focused on personal standards rather than group-level comparisons, which could attenuate aggressive responses toward out-groups. Taken together, these dynamics suggest that cultural frameworks shape both the cognitive and affective processes that underlie fan aggression. Of course, further research is clearly needed to elevate these assumptions about potential mechanisms and nuances to actual evidence.

In yet another intriguing finding, only the data of our Chinese sub-sample actually revealed a moderation effect of social media use: In this culture, the out-group hostility of sporadic social media users was more strongly connected to PSR levels, whereas frequent users showed weaker associations between the two. In our reading, this could actually indicate that increased social media engagement might also serve a positive purpose; fostering positive interactions with other fandoms, promoting empathy, and mitigating feelings of hostility regardless of the underlying PSR. These findings point to the importance of considering not only the strength of parasocial bonds but also the broader social and cultural context in which fandoms operate. For example, factors such as social norms around loyalty and competition, and culturally specific expectations regarding group behavior may all interact with individual psychological mechanisms to shape aggressive tendencies. Thus, we encourage follow-up studies including these variables to shed further light onto relevant dynamics.

Finally, our research examined that fans' aggressive feelings and willingness to improve the situation differed between specific situations (see RQ2). Interestingly, direct attacks—such as non-fans spreading rumors about or belittling one's idol—evoked stronger emotional reactions and defensive behavioral intentions than more indirect scenarios (e.g., collaborations between the idol and disliked celebrities). These findings suggest that fans are sensitive not only to the content of events but also to their perceived personal relevance and immediacy. Situations that directly challenge the fan's identification with their idol appear to trigger stronger protective responses, consistent with Social

Identity Theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1979). Indirect scenarios, while potentially annoying or frustrating, may not carry the same weight for the fan's self-concept, leading to milder emotional and behavioral reactions. Additionally, these patterns could reflect a general tendency for defensive behaviors to scale with perceived threat intensity, highlighting the role of situational appraisal in moderating aggressive responses.

Limitations and Future Research

Despite the gained insights, this study is subject to certain limitations. First, it relied on a cross-sectional design, which naturally limits the ability to draw causal conclusions regarding the relationships observed. To address this limitation, future research could employ longitudinal designs that track changes over time, allowing for the assessment of causal pathways in the emergence of attitudes and behaviors. Similar benefits could be offered by experimental studies that manipulate key variables and observe their direct effects on outcomes.

Second, the use of a non-representative convenience sample (i.e., rather young, well-educated, and predominantly female participants) limits the generalizability of the presented findings. Further research is clearly needed to replicate the presented evidence across more diverse samples.

Third, we have to presume that social desirability influences response patterns when investigating sensitive topics such as aggression or hostile cognitions; arguably; this is echoed by the rather low group means observed in our core variables. In future research, this issue could be addressed by including measurement tools such as the Social Desirability Scale (e.g., Kemper et al., 2012), so as to identify participants who may be responding in an especially desirable manner.

Fourth, several measures of the current study—such as the fan aggression scale—were developed in an ad-hoc manner (albeit based on existing instruments); accordingly, their construct validity remains untested. In addition, we must point out that participants' individual belief in values of interdependence (or their tendency toward individualism) was not explicitly measured in our work. This means that any interpretations of the observed cultural differences as a function of different cultural dimensions remains conjecture at this time.

Fifth, it is worth noting that the current study exclusively focused on positive PSRs, omitting an examination of negative PSRs. Yet, as individuals also form PSRs with celebrities toward whom they harbor antipathy, the question remains whether such negatively valenced relationships would equally contribute to adverse emotions and subsequent behavioral aggression—or much less so—than the positive counterparts that were observed in our study.

Lastly, a limitation of our study is that we did not differentiate between specific fandom types. While this allowed for a broader examination of parasocial and affective mechanisms across contexts, it also limited the depth of our findings. Future research should therefore examine whether and to what extent specific fandoms (e.g., music versus sports fandoms) differ in terms ofin-group identification or out-group hostility. Importantly, scientific inquiry into fandom should strive to capture the full spectrum of fan behavior, from everyday normative expressions of admiration to more intense or potentially problematic forms of engagement. While our study focused on selected affective and social mechanisms situated on the more maladaptive part of the continuum, we acknowledge the need for balanced perspectives that contextualize extreme cases within the broader, predominantly positive reality of fandom participation (Click & Scott, 2018; Duffett, 2013). This balanced approach allows for a more nuanced understanding of the sociopsychological dynamics that characterize fan communities. Aside from that, the clarification and conceptual distinction between fanship, fandom, and PSRs are essential for advancing scholarly precision in studying mediated fan phenomena. Conflating these constructs risks overlooking important psychological and social mechanisms, particularly when examining intergroup dynamics and affective responses within fan cultures.

Despite its limitations, we suggest that the present study offers an important next step in understanding fan culture: Stronger PSRs with celebrities from artistic/entertainment domains were significantly associated with increased in-group identification, out-group hostility, and behavioral aggression toward other fandoms from the same context. Additionally, significant cultural differences emerged, with fans from an East Asian society reporting stronger group-related fan dynamics than those form a Western nation. This highlights the role of cultural context in shaping fan dynamics, possibly linked to the influence of collectivist versus individualist cultural values. Fan behaviors and attitudes are likely embedded in broader sociocultural contexts that shape how individuals experience fanship and parasocial dynamics. Accordingly, future research should more systematically address cross-cultural differences in the structure, emotional intensity, and social function of fandoms. It is essential not to treat fandom as a culturally universal construct, but rather to acknowledge the influence of national values, platform ecosystems, and local media traditions in shaping fan-related experiences. Overall, our study expands the scope of fandom research by incorporating pop cultural fandoms and cross-cultural perspectives, underscoring the complexity of fan aggression across different cultural settings.

Author Contributions

CRediT: **Lisa Forner:** Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing; **Sarah Lutz:** Writing – review & editing; **Xuran Zheng:** Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Investigation, Methodology; **Jan-Philipp Stein:** Conceptualization, Project administration, Supervision, Writing – review & editing.

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